Train Story

By Adam Rapp

INTRODUCTION

On a cross-country train trip, an upper-middle class woman makes a strange connection with a pregnant teenager. Lori is an editor, and she is working on a particularly tiresome manuscript when Exley barges into her train car looking for drugs. Exley is about three months pregnant, and she is mad as all get-out that her boyfriend Morris hasn't met her on the train like he promised. Exley is obviously drunk, and the other passengers are afraid of her. When no one produces drugs for Exley, she pulls out a nail file that she calls a knife to threaten the passengers, and someone calls the conducter. The conductor knocks Exley to the floor of the train, and then handcuffs her to the seat across the aisle from Lori. The Train Story by Adam Rapp begins.

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WOMAN: The girl's nose is bleeding. I offer her my silk scarf. It's an expensive scaf, Hermes I think, but I don't mind. After all, it's the holiday season. She takes it ans stares at it appraisingly. For a moment I think she might stuff it in her pocket, but she balls it up and presses it into her face. I say, It's silk but don't worry about it. Are you okay?

GIRL: Three hours I waited for him. Three hours!

WOMAN: Who were you waiting for?

GIRL: Morris

WOMAN: Is that your boyfriend?

GIRL: Yeah

WOMAN: Is he the . . .

GIRL: The what?

WOMAN: Well, the father (no response . . . My name is Lori . . .. Lori Lansky

GIRL: Cool . . . Exley . . . . Yo, Lori Lansky, you got any pain relief?

WOMAN: I have aspirin. I reach into my purse and remove a small bottle of aspirin. I unscrew the top and hand her a few. While she's swallowing them, I realize that it's not her nose that's bleeding. Are you oaky?

GIRL: Why?

WOMAN: Well, it looks like you're losing some blood. We are quite. I mind my business. Out the window, the black fields have turned white. Somewhere along the way it has started to snow. Silently. Invisibly. The sun has fallen so fast it's as if the earth has slid on its axis. I look over and notice that Exley's lap is completely red now. Absurdly so. Like something from a horror movie.

GIRL: Yeah, go ahead and judge me lady.

WOMAN; I say, I'm not judging you. I am thinking, Don't judge her, Lori. Don't you dare judge her.

GIRL: You think god's gonna get me, don't you, Lori?

WOMAN: I wasn't thinking that at all.

GIRL: Yes you was. I can tell. Like he really give a dam. He too busy helpin' all the rich people.

WOMAN: I don't think God operates like that.

GIRL: Operates. Oh, he a surgeon now?

WOMAN: I don't think he discriminates according to economic stature. He'd be too dependent on the IRS. I think he exercises far mor subtlety . . . I'm not judging you, Exley. She looks at me with a kind of hunger. The way animals beg for food with their eyes. With this look I realize that she's much younger than I thought. Her skin is too fragile. Her

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cheeks too soft. She may be fifteen, sixteen. For some reason, I ask her if she believes in God. Do you believe in God, Exley?

GIRL: Not really. I mean, when I used to see Jesus in those Easter movies I thought he was cool. Like how he walked on water and whatnot. There was this one where he turned all this bred into tropical fish. That was pretty dope . . . Why, do you?

WOMAN: I don't know.

GIRL: What do you believe in, credit cards? Fancy clothes catalogs?

WOMAN: I believe in luck, I guess.

GIRL: That's prolly why you don't fly. Luck

WOMAN: It's true. I have this fear that things would go bad for me on a plane. That I'd lose myself somehow.

GIRL: That how I feel about trains. I kept tellin' Morris we shoulda drove. He just bought a '99 BMW.

WOMAN: Is Morris the father?

GIRL: I think so.

WOMAN: Where were you two planning on going?

GIRL: I don't know. Somewhere west. Like the ocean maybe. Swim with the starfish. Chill with the electric eels. He said he had a partner out there. On some beach with an Italian name.

WOMAN: Venice Beach. Well, wherever you wind up, I wish you luck, Exley.

She doesn't respond. It's as if I've stung her. Sure, an overly educated, more fortunate white woman in designer clothes can just throw Luck around. It's a mild luxury like potpourri or expensive soap.

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When the conductor re-enters I tell him how Exley may be hemorrhaging from her uterus and he calls the paramedics on his walkie-talkie. She is staring out the window as if there is something in the barren fields that will pardon her. As if there is a fairy tale about poor white girls that has yet to be written.

We lock eyes for a moment. Bravely. Somehow longingly. I never used to believe that strangers shared these kind of moments. In real life these exchanges are simply anecdotes. It's never about yearning or frailty or pure, wordless human contact.

By the time the train stops in Indiana Exley has lost consciousness. There is an enormous volume of blood pooling in her lap When the doors open there are policemen. There are station managers. There are paramedics as silent as aliens. Far too many men to move the body of a small, lifeless girl.

I tell one of the paramedic that I think it's a botched abortion. I give him the number of where I'm staying and ask him to call me. To let me know if she makes it through.

A few weeks after I get back to New York I start to feel sick in the mornings. I think I must have gotten a bug from traveling. Something from the other coast. Three weeks later I miss my period. I buy an over-the-counter pregnancy test. It turns out positive.

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I'm two months along now. My appetite has changes. I have told no one. Not even the father. I often think of Exley. That paramedic never called me. I don't recall what she did or said so much as her will. How it burned through her skin. That lost white orchid. Did she make it through? Did someone find her at the hospital? A priest? A policeman? Is she wandering the snow-swept highways of Indiana? There are certain hors of the night when I wake to the sound of a train. It roars right through my apartment. At times it feels as if it will life me out of bed. All that earsplitting thunder and then silence. A quiet that can't be captured in prose or likened to certain kinds of weather. A calm that defies even thought. Just the purest absence of noise.

Perhaps souls have the ability to leap from womb to womb?

I am alone, Exley. I am very much alone in a city that at time makes people feel old and used. But I am somehow lucky. Even during the darkest hour I manage to always pull through . . .

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Adam Rapp
Book: The Best American Short Plays 2000-2001
ISBN: 1557834806
Publisher: Applause Theatre Books
Date (Month/Year): 2002